"What helped me navigate those situations was developing deep expertise and staying relentlessly focused on delivering meaningful outcomes. I learned early on that sustained performance is the most powerful equaliser," she says. The turning point for her came when she was asked to establish the business in the US—among the world's most competitive pharma markets—in the late 1990s. , Lupin is the third-largest pharma company in the US as per prescriptions filled with over 150 commercialised products. Along with this, Gupta, who took over as CEO in 2013, takes pride in the company's transformation into a more innovation-driven, future-ready organisation over the past five years.

The same philosophy holds true for Rama Kirloskar, Joint Managing Director, Kirloskar Brothers. Walking into an established business built by the generations before you has its advantages, but the onus to build trust and credibility still remains. "In our family, there has never really been a distinction between men and women in the business, whether in terms of working in the company or leading it. The bigger challenge, therefore, was not being a woman in a male-dominated field; it was establishing credibility and showing that I could contribute meaningfully to the business," she says.

Over the past few years, she's worked at making Kirloskar Ebara Pumps debt free, in part by moving from volume-led manufacturing to creating more specialised engineering applications. (Kirloskar Ebara Pumps is a joint venture between Kirloskar Brothers and Japan's Ebara Corporation.) Alongside, she made operational and portfolio-level changes across the group, resulting in an overall improvement in capital efficiency and margins across group businesses.

For her, leadership is not about asserting authority. "It is about earning



IT IS ABOUT EARNING TRUST, MAKING DECISIONS WHEN THEY NEED TO BE MADE AND TAKING RESPONSIBILITY"

RAMA KIRLOSKAR
JOINT MANAGING DIRECTOR, KIRLOSKAR BROTHERS

+ Also serves at Managing Director, Kirloskar Ebara Pumps. Played an important role in restructuring the business, overseeing the go-to-market strategy and restructuring mass production, foundry and made-to-order businesses

+ On the Executive Council of AGNIi (Accelerating Growth of New India's Innovations), a programme of the Office of the Principal Scientific Adviser to the Government of India and a Mission under the Prime Minister's Science Technology and Innovation Advisory Council

PHOTOS BY **MILIND SHELTE**